Zahhak – a "repugnant figure in the Iranian lands farther to the west … [but commanding] popularity in the region of Ghazna and Zabulistan."[18]

Indeed, Juzjani dutifully provided a surfeit of origin stories for the obscure transhumant clan who would come to be recorded in his and others' chronicles as the Shansabanis. Addressing an array of the historiographical registers of his time, the author also granted a seemingly unassailable Islamic pedigree to his patrons, claiming their conversion to Islam by none other than the *khalifa* 'Ali himself during the first century of the Hijra.[19] Additionally, Chapter 2 posits that Juzjani couched a possible reference to their rural and probably nomadic-transhumant origins and the beginnings of their transformation to elite status: A story in *Tabaqat* centered on the Shansabanis' mythical progenitor Amir Banji and the friendly Jewish merchant who became his ally and advisor comes across as the parable-like narrative of upward politico-economic mobility. As apocryphal as the story undoubtedly is, we are nonetheless tempted to credit Juzjani with an uncanny prescience, as if he had laid the crumbs along the evidentiary trail sought by the modern investigator.

Tabaqat ensued from Juzjani's own family history and recollections. The author was close to and invested in the Shansabanis' activities in Khurasan (modern Afghanistan and contiguous areas; map, p. xv), as a result producing a virtually unique account of the early dynastic history of his patrons.[20] Additionally, *Tabaqat* drew from another, equally first-hand work that is unfortunately no longer extant: a versified genealogy by Fakhr al-Din Mubarak-shah al-Marwarruzi (d. AH 601/1205 CE).[21] This Persian-Arabic poet and writer on astronomy had dedicated the work to Sultan 'Ala' al-Din Husain *Jahan-suz* (r. AH 544–556/1150–1161 CE), and thereafter had continued in royal service, being mentioned as a *nadim* in the retinue of Sultan Ghiyath al-Din Muhammad ibn Sam (r. AH 558–599/1163–1203 CE). Juzjani apparently consulted the genealogy in the possession of Mah Malik, the daughter of Sultan Ghiyath al-Din residing at Firuzkuh.[22]

Ghur's main economies of nomadism–transhumance rather than commerce, and the region's general difficulty of access meant that the aforementioned universal histories, such as Ibn al-Athir's *Kamil*, often gathered information that was second-hand – though it was not necessarily unreliable (cf. below). Moreover, rather than re-litigating the factuality of reported events among historical sources – already undertaken by others[23] – Juzjani and his *Tabaqat* act as the primary textual interlocutors throughout this volume. Not only is *Tabaqat* the sole surviving work essentially devoted to the Shansabanis, it also furnishes the most fleshed out account of their early trajectory prior to the eastward expansions of the Ghazna branch – albeit according to its author's priorities (cf. below and Chapters 2–4). Juzjani's own professional and geographical movements curiously recapitulated those of his Shansabani patrons: he faithfully served them throughout much of his life, also